

"They saw her
stone-dead,
lying upon a
bed of gold ...
in all her royal
ornaments."

PLUTARCH RECOUNTS THE DEATH OF CLEOPATRA IN
LIFE OF ANTONY (LXXXV.2-3, DRYDEN TRANS.)

DYING WITH HONOR

Queen Cleopatra VII was the last ruler of Ptolemaic Egypt. Politically astute and beautiful, she became the lover of the Roman politician, Julius Caesar; later, after the death of Caesar, she became the ally and lover of his supporter, Mark Antony. In 30 BCE, Roman forces led by Octavian, Caesar's heir, invaded Egypt and defeated the armies of Cleopatra and Marc Antony at Actium. After Marc Antony killed himself, Cleopatra, wishing to avoid the humiliation of being paraded as a prisoner when Octavian's victory was celebrated, also took her own life (the aftermath of which is depicted here). While many accounts claim that Cleopatra poisoned herself by letting an asp (Egyptian cobra) bite her, it is medically unlikely that such a bite would have killed her. Some historians have theorized that she was murdered by Octavian, who saw the powerful queen as too great a threat.

